



▲ HENRY THE NAVIGATOR

Prince Henry of Portugal earned himself the nickname “Henry the Navigator,” despite never setting off on any voyages himself. He funded expeditions from Portugal to explore the West African coast, which was then unknown to Europeans. For them, these journeys kick-started the era sometimes called the Age of Exploration.

European expansion

Since ancient times, Europeans had been aware of the regions surrounding the Mediterranean, as well as parts of Asia and North Africa. But in the 15th century, they began to set their sights on places farther afield, taking to the open seas to find what lay beyond the edges of their maps.

There were many reasons for the European yearning for exploration, but, at least to begin with, seizing foreign lands was not one of them. Expensive goods such as silk and spices arrived overland from Asia, and the first European expeditions aimed to establish a faster, safer sea route in order to expand trade.

However, as explorers began to realize the abundance of resources in the lands they visited, they started seizing territory by force, often using their superior weapons to kill or enslave Indigenous people living there.

The first expeditions in the mid-15th century began a centuries-long campaign of European expansion and colonization. By the start of World War I in 1914, European nations had conquered more than 80 percent of the land on the planet, and the effects of this violent colonization are still felt across the globe today (see pp.172–173).



SAILING ESSENTIALS

New inventions and technologies made the Age of Exploration possible. The Portuguese developed small, fast, and powerful ships called caravels to explore the vast oceans. Navigational instruments such as the astrolabe and backstaff helped sailors figure out their location while at sea.



ASTROLABE

Triangular sails allowed the ship to “tack” (zigzag into the wind).



MODEL OF CARAVEL



BACKSTAFF



VOYAGES TO AFRICA ►

During his exploration of East Africa, Portuguese navigator Diogo Cão discovered that the continent was bigger than Europeans had previously thought. He erected stone pillars called padraões (right) to mark his progress and claim land. Later explorers to Africa continued this custom.

▲ COLUMBIAN EXCHANGE

Between 1492 and 1504, Italian explorer Christopher Columbus made four voyages to the Americas, establishing the first links of a connection between Europe and the Americas. Fruits and vegetables such as pineapples and sweet potatoes were shipped to Europe, while livestock and crops such as wheat were introduced to the Americas—as were deadly diseases such as smallpox. The early trade of goods, ideas, and diseases between the two regions was known as the Columbian Exchange.